How it started

Rooted Forward was started by Zain Zaidi, a student who lives on the Near South Side and goes to school in Hyde Park. Going between the two every day, he kept running into the bubble around the University of Chicago, and how completely the city changed from one block to the next.

Looking for why, Zain learned how discriminatory urban development was carried out through practices like redlining, restrictive covenants, and urban renewal. He wanted to share that knowledge with others and drive policy change.

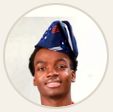
Students in other large American cities had seen the same patterns where they live, and joined him.

We are active in Chicago, New York, and Washington, DC.

Leadership team



Zain Zaidi
Chicago
University of Chicago Laboratory Schools



Ayomide Olatunji
Chicago
Harvard University



Sammar Agha
Dallas
Greenhill School



Osheanna Tyler-Hudson
Chicago
DePaul University



Sabina Aliyev
New York
Xaverian High School



Javonte White
Chicago
Collins Academy High School

Learn more about Rooted Forward

Take a tour or sign one of our petitions on our website, or write to us.

rooted-forward.org

contact@rooted-forward.org

We could use your help

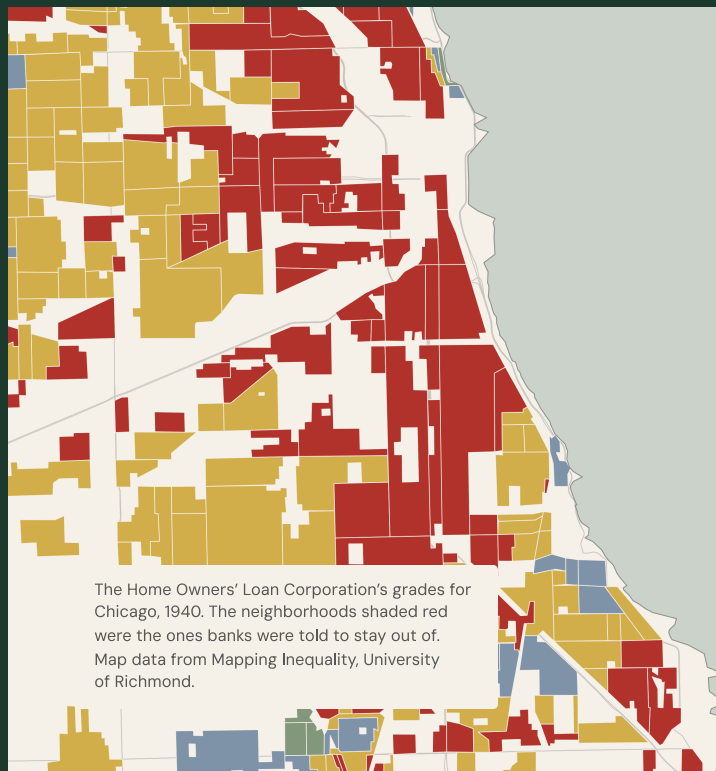
We want to partner with people and organizations who can help us bring this message to more people. If you or your organization would like our materials, we are happy to supply them.

We are also looking for people to help with archival research. You do not need experience to start.

Rooted Forward

Rooted Forward

A student-run nonprofit started in Chicago. Rooted Forward raises awareness of racial inequality in cities across the United States, and works to address it through education and political advocacy.



The Home Owners' Loan Corporation's grades for Chicago, 1940. The neighborhoods shaded red were the ones banks were told to stay out of. Map data from Mapping Inequality, University of Richmond.

Ways we help



The plaza of the Obama Presidential Center on opening day, June 19, 2026. Photograph by AlphaBeta135, via Wikimedia Commons. CC0.



The route of Walk Hyde Park, the first tour in the app.



The map and its touch screen on the museum's wall in Bridgeport, September 2026. Photograph by Rooted Forward.

Community outreach

We do outreach and education in the community, showing people this history and our work and promoting our free tours. We have held events at farmers' markets and community events.

Self-guided walking tours

Students research one neighborhood at a time and build a tour out of what they find. It lives on the Rooted Forward app, free to walk or to read at home.

Museum partnerships

We partner with museums, among them the Glessner House, the Japanese American Service Committee's Legacy Center, and the Chicago Maritime Museum.

Policy advocacy

We run petitions on bills that are already introduced and stuck in a committee, then submit the signatures as public comment.

Scan for the tours

rooted-forward.org/tours

School visits

We visit schools, including Hyde Park Academy, and present our research to students.